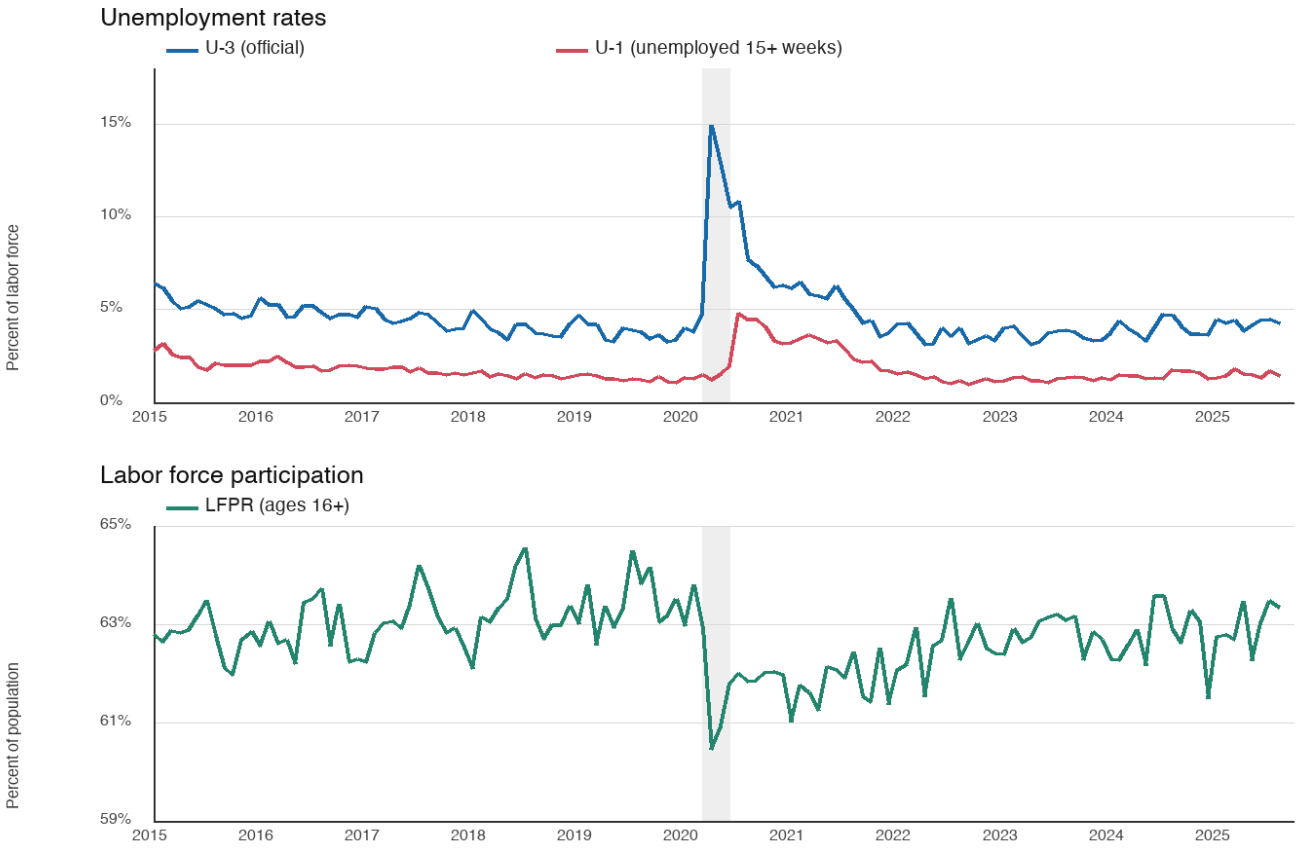
Alternative measures of unemployment

IPUMS CPS basic monthly, January 2015 to August 2025



Source: IPUMS CPS basic monthly extract, weighted with WTFINL. Gray shading: March-May 2020.

Selected months

Period	U-3	U-1	LFPR
2019 average	3.78%	1.30%	63.44%
Feb 2020	3.83%	1.29%	63.81%
April 2020	14.95%	1.23%	60.46%
Latest (Aug 2025)	4.30%	1.42%	63.34%

Interpretation

By August 2025, U-3 was 4.30%, near February 2020's 3.83% and the 2019 average of 3.78%, consistent with broad recovery. U-1 was 1.42%, just 0.13 percentage points above February 2020 and 0.12 percentage points above 2019, so it signals little remaining long-term unemployment slack. LFPR was 63.34%, 0.47 points below February 2020 and 0.10 below 2019; population aging may explain part of the gap. U-1 agrees with U-3, while LFPR is a slightly softer signal, illustrating Gilchrist and Hobijn's point that slack measures can diverge.

Methods

Monthly estimates use WTFINL person weights. U-1 is unemployed 15+ weeks as a share of the labor force; LFPR is the labor force divided by the population age 16 and older. The continuous monthly series runs from January 2015 through August 2025. Gray shading marks March-May 2020. Source: IPUMS CPS basic monthly extract.